

ILLXL

The Illest Excel Add-In for Finance Pros

50+ keyboard shortcuts across 7 modules — number formatting, borders, input styles, header styles, unit tags, formula tools, and core utilities. A powerful free alternative to WSP Boost, WST Macros, and Macabacus. Built by Bruce Zachary Illes.

50+

KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

7

MODULES

FREE

ALWAYS

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modCore -- Utilities

Performance mode, navigation helpers, and formula reference tools.

SHORTCUT	ACTION
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+M	Toggle Performance Mode (Manual Calc, Screen Off, No Undo)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+A	Make Cell References Absolute (\$A\$1 style)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+R	Make Cell References Relative (A1 style)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+N	Go To Next Blank Cell in Selection
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+E	Go To Next Error Cell in Selection
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+L	Break External Links in Selection (converts to values)

modFormatCycles -- Number Formats

Cycle through professional formats. Press repeatedly to advance. Resets when selection changes.

SHORTCUT	ACTION
Ctrl+Shift+1	Cycle Number Format #,##0 -> K -> M
Ctrl+Shift+3	Cycle Date Format m/d/yyyy -> m/d/yy -> yyyy-mm-dd -> mmm-yy -> d-mmm-yy
Ctrl+Shift+4	Cycle Currency Format \$#,##0 -> \$K -> \$M
Ctrl+Shift+5	Cycle Percent Format 0.0% -> 0% -> +0.0%/-0.0% -> hide if ~0 -> 0.0% hide zero
Ctrl+Shift+8	Cycle Other Formats A=Actual B=Budget F=Forecast Q=Quarter P=Period E=Estimate x=multiple
Ctrl+Shift+>	Increase Decimal Places
Ctrl+Shift+<	Decrease Decimal Places
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+\	Toggle Sign (positive <-> negative)
Ctrl+Alt+2	Divide by 100 (e.g., 5 -> 0.05 for percentage entry)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+2	Multiply by 100 (e.g., 0.05 -> 5)

modStyles -- Colors, Fonts & Layout

Input styles, header styles, font/fill cycles, indent, and conditional formatting.

SHORTCUT	ACTION
Ctrl+Alt+A	Auto-Color Blue=input / Black=formula / Green=sheet ref / Red=ext link
Ctrl+'	Cycle Font Aptos Narrow -> Poppins -> Times New Roman
Ctrl+Shift+K	Cycle Fill None -> Yellow -> Gray -> Diag Stripe -> Black -> Green -> Red -> Magenta
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+I	Cycle Text Case Title Case -> lower case -> UPPER CASE
Ctrl+Shift+C	Cycle Font Color Blue -> Green -> Black -> Red -> Gray -> Purple -> White
Ctrl+Shift+F	Increase Font Size (+1pt)
Ctrl+Shift+G	Decrease Font Size (-1pt)
Ctrl+Alt+>	Indent In (auto left-aligns so indent is visible)
Ctrl+Alt+<	Indent Out (resets to general align at zero indent)
Ctrl+Alt+E	Center Across Selection -- no more Merge & Center, one keystroke
Ctrl+Shift+N	Insert Static Timestamp (last-updated stamp for model review)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+U	Cycle Input Style Yellow -> Lt Yellow -> Gray -> Peach -> Pale Blue
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+H	Cycle Header Style Sangoma Navy -> Mid Navy -> Black -> Blue
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Y	Insert Headers from Prompt (e.g. 2024A, 2025B, 2026E)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+D	Insert Variance Headers (AvF % / AvB % / Var AvB)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Z	Apply Zero-Check CF (green if =0 / red if <>0 -- balance sheet check)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+X	Clear Zero-Check Conditional Formatting

modFormulas -- Formula Tools

CAGR, % change, growth rates, and aggregation shortcuts for financial modeling.

SHORTCUT	ACTION
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+C	Insert CAGR $= (\text{End}/\text{Begin})^{(1/n)} - 1$ -- n = end year MINUS start year (2023->2026 = 3, not 4)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+W	Insert % Change $= (\text{Current} - \text{Prior}) / \text{ABS}(\text{Prior})$ -- refs cells to the left
Ctrl+Alt+L	Equals Left -- each cell gets =CELLTOLEFT (e.g. select C5:F5, each links left across)
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+G	Apply Growth Rate $= \text{LEFT} * (1 + \text{rate})$ -- prompts for rate input
Ctrl+Alt+=	Quick SUM -- select destination cell, then pick the range to sum
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+=	Quick Average -- select destination cell, then pick the range



modBorders -- Border Cycles

Each border shortcut cycles: Thin -> None -> Medium -> Hairline. Resets when selection changes.

SHORTCUT	ACTION
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Up	Cycle Top Border Thin -> None -> Medium -> Hairline
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Down	Cycle Bottom Border Thin -> None -> Medium -> Hairline
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Left	Cycle Left Border Thin -> None -> Medium -> Hairline
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Right	Cycle Right Border Thin -> None -> Medium -> Hairline
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+B	Apply Outline (Medium) + Inside (Thin) Borders to Selection
Ctrl+Alt+-	Apply Sum Bar (single underline below totals)
Ctrl+Alt+_	Apply Double Sum Bar (double underline below grand totals)

modUnitTags -- Unit Tags

FAST-standard tags. Two keystrokes to label any row. Works on non-formula cells only.

SHORTCUT	ACTION
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+T	Cycle Value Tag: [#] [%] [mIn \$] [thd \$] [bn \$] [x] [pp] [bps]
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+O	Cycle Duration Tag: [d] [m] [q] [y]
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+P	Cycle Rate Tag: [%/y] [\$ /unit] [\$ /FTE] [\$ /yr]
Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Backspace	Remove Last Unit Tag from Selected Cells

Pro Tips & How It Works

Performance Mode

Turn ON before mass formatting, large copy/fill, or applying CF to many cells. Disables auto-calc, screen updates, events, and the undo buffer. Turn OFF when done -- Ctrl+Z history is fully restored.

Cycle Logic

All cycles (number format, border, fill, font color, unit tag) are per-cell aware. Changing your selection resets the cycle counter so the next press always starts from step 1.

Unit Tags + FAST Standard

Tags follow the FAST financial modeling standard. Two keystrokes cycles through every standard unit -- [mln \$], [%], [x], [bps] and more. No more typing tags manually. Empty cells receive just the tag; existing tags replace in-place.

Zero-Check CF

Built for balance sheet checks: apply to a balance cell and it turns green if zero (balanced) and red if not. Two keystrokes vs a full conditional formatting dialog.

Insert Static Now

Stamps the current date and time as a static value -- not a formula. Perfect for recording when a model section was last updated or a review was completed.

Auto-Color

Run on your entire model to instantly distinguish: hardcodes (blue), external workbook links (red), cross-sheet refs (green), formula-only cells (black).

Scale Up / Down

ScaleUp wraps the existing formula: =(original_formula)/1000. ScaleDown multiplies: =(original_formula)*1000. The formula stays intact and fully auditable.

Undo Support

All shortcuts support Ctrl+Z via a custom undo buffer (up to 5,000 cells). The buffer captures values, formulas, and number formats simultaneously.

Nuisance Keys Disabled

On load, ILLXL silently disables four keys that cause accidental disruption in Excel: F1 (Help dialog), Scroll Lock, Num Lock, and Insert (overtyping mode). These fire constantly by accident and almost never intentionally -- they are now harmless.

Input Style Color Reference (Ctrl+Alt+Shift+U cycle)

STEP	STYLE	FILL	FONT	TYPICAL USE CASE
1	Yellow	#FFF2CC	Blue	Primary hardcoded assumptions
2	Light Yellow	#FFFFCC	Blue	Secondary / supporting assumptions
3	Gray	#D9D9D9	Blue	Linked / locked / non-editable cells
4	Peach	#FFC799	Teal	Special flagged or exception inputs
5	Pale Blue	#DDEBF7	Dark Blue	Override cells (model exceptions)